taboo. Kaaru plays obscure Bollywood songs from my youth that I haven't heard in decades, and which now evoke a mood of nostalgic delight.

Kaaru drives through a village where Nitish Kumar spent some of his childhood years, which explains its new large public high school and hospital. While this is atypical, things in Bihar have in fact improved more broadly in the last dozen years. Its rural road network is better; most rural homes have electricity most of the time and primary school attendance is notably higher. While the overall literacy rate in Nalanda district was still only about 70 per cent in 2018, it had risen from about 50 per cent in 2006, a gain partly attributable to the government's policies and partly to rising aspirations unleashed across India by economic liberalization.

But while the fortunes of most Biharis seem better, the state still lags behind much of the country, owing to its high rates of landlessness, poverty and population growth; rampant political corruption; stronger hold of caste and its dysfunction; and poor industrial development. Its crushing material squalor goes hand in hand with some of the worst human development indicators in India. Schools impart few useful skills and suffer from chronic absenteeism and a high dropout rate. I see lots of kids with reddish-orange hair in towns and villages—indicating malnutrition and perhaps long-term learning disabilities, though fewer kids now have the distended bellies I saw on my previous visit in 2006. Journalist Mark Tully had claimed around then that 'Biharis themselves say it's the only place in the world where the state has withered away, fulfilling Karl Marx's prophecy'.

But the state has clearly sprung back and introduced moves like a total ban on alcohol, enforced with fines of Rs 50,000 and/or three months in jail. Making Bihar a dry state was Kumar's campaign promise to the people—mostly poor women fed up with their husbands wasting money on booze. Consumption has fallen sharply, though, as I later learn from a friend in Patna, there's now illicit home delivery of liquor for those who can pay. Some villagers, Kaaru says, have resorted to home brews like mahua. The cops fear these villagers and don't bother them. Something of the old jungle raj—or the spirit of lawlessness usually associated with frontiers—is alive and well in Bihar. People still resort to vigilante justice. A few days after my visit, a woman suspected of a crime in a neighbouring district is beaten by a mob and paraded naked through the streets.[1]